

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: property-management-software • 120 Doors Mixed SFR + 8-Plexes • Buildium + QBO to Trust Accounting + Maintenance Workflow

2026-05-14 09:12 AM

DecisionBrief: Evaluating property management software? Tell me a bit about your role and the portfolio you manage today?

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You: I'm owner-operator, self-managing 120 doors — 80 single-family rentals and 40 units across five 8-plexes, all in DFW. Team is me plus 2 office staff and 1 field tech who does turn checks.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — 120 doors, mixed SFR and small multifamily, lean 4-person team. What system handles accounting and tenant/maintenance tracking today?

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You: Buildium for 3 years, QuickBooks Online for our corporate books, plus spreadsheets for owner statements. Maintenance is messy — tenants call/text, my coordinator logs in Buildium then calls vendors by phone, no vendor portal. Owner statements take me 2 full days at month-end.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — Buildium + QBO + spreadsheets, owner close is 2-day bottleneck. What volume of maintenance and leasing are you seeing?

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You: About 30 maintenance work orders a week, 40 leases a year, and 15 owner reports per month. Turns are killing us in summer — photos and receipts are in text threads, not tied to the work order.

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DecisionBrief: That's heavy — 30 WOs/week with photos lost in texts. Have you tried other software before Buildium?

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You: Yeah, we were on AppFolio for 8 months four years ago when we were 70 doors — too expensive per unit and forced their payment processing fees. Before Buildium it was just Excel and QBO, which was chaos for trust accounting.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — AppFolio too pricey, Excel broke trust accounting. Beyond fixing accounting, what must-haves would make a switch worth it?

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You: True trust accounting that reconciles, QBO sync that actually syncs without double entry, owner portal where owners see per-property P&L; and docs themselves, maintenance lifecycle with photos, vendor assignment, and billing tied to the work order. Mobile app for my field tech is a must.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — trust accounting, real QBO sync, owner portal P&L;, full WO lifecycle with photos/billing, mobile field app. What constraints or blackout dates should we respect?

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You: Budget under \$250/month all-in, must migrate 2 years of history — leases, ledgers, open WOs. Needs onboarding help, not just videos. And we cannot switch during renewal season Oct-Dec, that's blackout — too risky for lease mistakes.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — <\$250/mo, 2-year migration, hands-on onboarding, no go-live Oct-Dec. What worries you most about switching PMS?

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You: Data migration messing up security deposits and owner balances — that's lawsuit territory. Also double-entry creeping back if QBO sync breaks, and vendors ignoring a new portal. If maintenance gets worse, tenants churn.

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DecisionBrief: Thanks — deposit integrity and vendor adoption are key risks. If this works, what does success look like in 6 months?

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You: Month-end close in 4 hours not 2 days, owners self-serve their statements and don't text me, every work order has photos and receipt attached and billed to right property, and no double entry between PMS and QBO. Buildium price increase is pushing us, but we won't switch just to save \$30 if accounting is worse.

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DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.